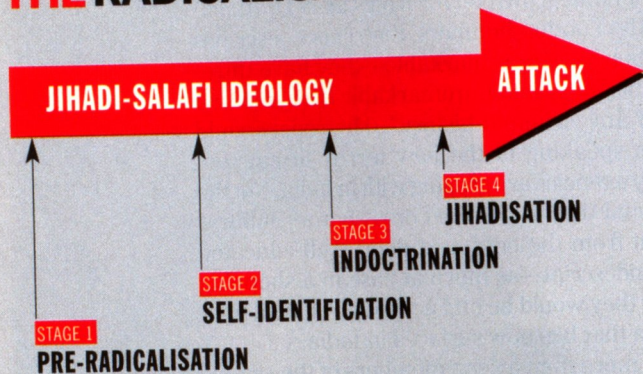
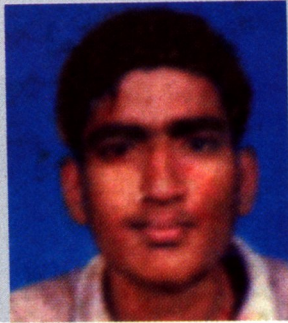


THE RADICALISATION ROAD



Each of these phases is unique and has specific signatures associated with it. All individuals who begin this process do not necessarily pass through all the stages and many, in fact, stop or abandon this process at different points. Moreover, although this model is sequential, individuals do not always follow a linear progression. However, individuals who do pass through the entire process are most likely to be involved in a terrorist act.

Radicalization in the West—the homegrown threat by NIPD Intelligence Division



MASTER-MINDS: (Left) Bashir, the spiritual sanctioner and Atif, the operational leader

with SIMI. While the top leadership was nabbed, the other 'clean skins' who attended the camps remain at large, radicalised and ready to serve as mentors or tomorrows terrorists.

Nabbing the 'Nagori 13', as they were called, gave security agencies a peep into the amorphous nature of the post-9/11 threat confronting them. It has become increasingly difficult to identify terror groups simply because they form a loose conglomeration of hybrid groups, opportunistic and capable of rapid transformation. The Indian Mujahideen are thought to be SIMI members, funded by the Lashkar and also a rebranded version of the Asif Raza Commando Force behind the 2001 attack on the American Centre in Kolkata. These are fluid groups without rigid structures

and can easily turn volatile. Members travelled between groups. SIMI's Hyderabad-born member Naser, for instance, was among a handful of youth trained in a Lashkar camp in Pakistan and was in touch with Harkat-ul-Jihad-al Islami (HUJI) mastermind Shahid Bilal.

A majority of these youth form part of a global post-9/11 trend. Inspired by Al Qaeda's jihadi ideology but firmly anchored in local grievances, these youth moulded their new identities based on the puritanical and intolerant Wahhabi ideology. An ideology morphs into a personal cause as the individual identifies with his group. Terrorism is the ultimate consequence of the radicalisation process which legitimises terrorism as a tool to affect societal change.

Aiding the extremist in a four-stage progression (see box) towards jihadisation are radicalisation accelerants like the Internet—hate sites and chatrooms. Like the Ahmedabad-Jaipur-Delhi bombers compartmentalised into different state-specific modules by a shadowy 12-member supreme leadership, they are separated into state-wise modules so that members of one module would not compromise the others in case of arrest. This also explains the confusion between the claims of various state police units.

Motivating the extremist on the path of jihad are two key persons. The 'spiritual sanctioner' who provides religious justification for jihad and the 'operational leader' who provides training, motivation, discipline and cohesiveness. Intelligence agencies believe Azamgarh cleric Abu Bashir was the spiritual sanctioner while Atif was the operational leader of the Batla House boys who struck in Jaipur, Ahmedabad and Delhi. These attacks are part of a continuum which has spread out of the confines of J&K and seeped into the Indian heartland, attacking the soft underbelly of its crowded population centres. The attacks use the old boy networks and contacts established by the Mumbai and Gujarat underworld and SIMI. External agents—like the ISI's Karachi-based underworld henchman Rasool Parti—are believed to have financed the blasts. Beyond the horror of the body count, paralysing the will of the state, the target is a booming Indian economy.

"Terrorism can destroy nations if allowed to

“ The accused gloated over their acts of terror and were planning more attacks. ”

H.G.S. DHALIWAL, DCP SOUTH, DELHI POLICE

